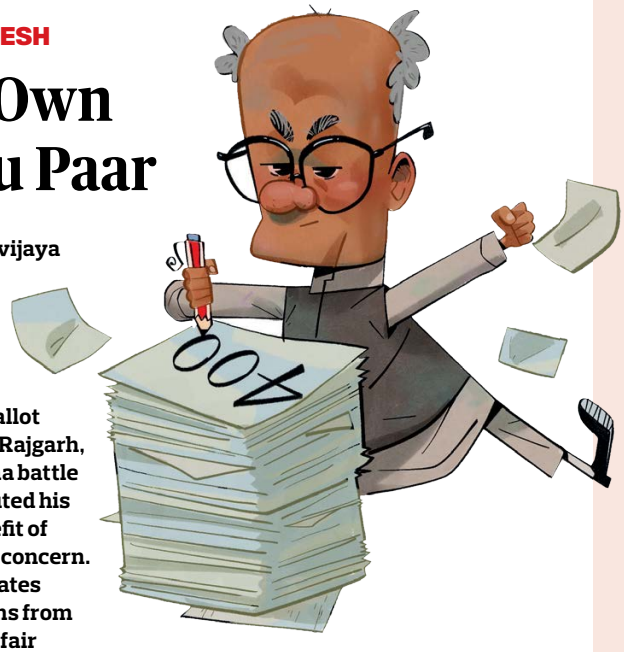
▶ MADHYA PRADESH

Diggy's Own Char Sau Paar



Former CM Digvijaya Singh, among the loudest critics of EVMs, has come upon a novel way to ensure elections through ballot papers. Speaking in Rajgarh, his chosen Lok Sabha battle arena, Diggy Raja outed his formula for the benefit of whomsoever it may concern. "At least 400 candidates must file nominations from Rajgarh, if you want fair elections," he said. Why 400? Because each master unit can be linked to 24 ballot units inside an EVM, and each ballot unit can accommodate 16 candidates, including NOTA. So if the number of candidates exceeds 24 x 16 i.e. 384, poll officials would have no option but to opt for ballot papers! ■



12. DARSHANA JARDOSH (BJP) • *Surat, Gujarat, Winning margin* **548,230**



14. P VELUSAMY (DMK) • *Dindigul, Tamil Nadu, Winning margin* **538,972**



16. RAMAKANT BHARGAVA (BJP) • *Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh, Winning margin* **503,084**



17. V.K. SINGH (BJP) • *Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, Winning margin* **501,500**



20. PASHUPATI NATH SINGH (BJP) • *Dhanbad, Jharkhand, Winning margin* **486,194**

▶ KERALA

HIT PAWS

The Congress manifesto really sank its teeth into something that's nobody's pet theme yet: stray dogs. The party has promised to "protect humans" while being "humanitarian" towards animals. Incidents of dog bites rose from 2.18 million in 2022 to 2.75 million in 2023, up by 27 per cent. The situation is particularly alarming in Kerala, which saw cases surge from 4,000 in 2022 to 16,133 in 2023, with gory details hitting the front pages. Cases in Delhi too nearly trebled: from 6,634 to 16,133. That's 27 seats in all...so, a party's best friend? ■

MISSING IN ACTION



Till now, let's say, he has been more renowned for not letting go. His total immersion in Rajasthan's power stakes makes the absence of **Ashok Gehlot** from the LS poll fray even more conspicuous–some attribute the avoidance to fear of losing. Except for trying to see his son Vaibhav through in Jalore-Sirohi, the ex-CM has been mostly abdicating.



The other half of the binary for the Congress in Rajasthan, **Sachin Pilot**, too has dodged the draft. He was active in candidate selection and is out campaigning enthusiastically, at least for his chosen people. But with his personal popularity, especially in the eastern belt, direct presence in the battlefield could have altered outcomes beyond one seat.



Of the three, **Vasundhara Raje**'s recusal from Lok Sabha candidacy is the most understandable–she clearly hasn't forgotten how the party snubbed her after profiting from all the hard work she put in for the assembly polls; even her nominees did not get a place in cabinet. Now the BJP waits to see if she campaigns beyond son Dushyant's Jhalawar-Baran.

Anilesh S. Mahajan, Arkamoy Dutta Majumdar, Amarnath K. Menon, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rohit Parihar, Prashant Srivastava, Ajay Sukumaran and Kaushik Deka